Nivela 3D

BONUS · NIVELA 3D

# First Sales with Profit

How to take your printer from hobby to business and make your first sales without leaving money on the table.

Exclusive bonus for Nivela 3D customers.

PART 01

# Why so many people sell and don't profit

Selling more doesn't mean earning more. In 3D printing, money slips away through costs that don't show up when you set the price.

Beginners usually look only at filament. A piece that uses $3 of material becomes "$15 price, $12 profit". But that math leaves out:

- **Electricity** for every hour the printer runs.
- **Wear** on the nozzle, build plate, belts and the machine itself, which will need replacing one day.
- **Failed prints**: parts that come loose, clog or warp. They eat material and time and never become a sale.
- **Your time**: slicing, monitoring, removing supports, sanding, packing, answering customers.
- **Supplies**: packaging, labels, glue, magnets, key rings, paint.
- **Channel fees**: card processing, marketplace fees, shipping you absorb.

**Example:** a piece sold for $25 seems to make $21 profit when only filament ($4) is counted. Add electricity, wear, failures, labor, packaging and fees and the real profit can drop to around $7. This guide helps you plug that invisible leak.

PART 02

# Pick 3 products to start

Starting with everything is the fastest way to get lost. Pick three pieces and learn to sell those three well.

Good starter products have these traits:

- They print in **a few hours** with a **low failure rate** on your machine.
- They need **little finishing** (not much support to remove).
- They solve a problem or make a great gift: **utility or emotion**.
- They can be **personalized** (name, color, phrase). Personalization lets you charge more.
- They **don't use third-party brands, characters or logos** without a license. On Etsy, 3D printed items must also be **your own original design**.

A combination that works: **1 low-priced entry piece** (e.g. name keychain), **1 useful piece** (e.g. desk organizer) and **1 gift piece** (e.g. vase or lamp). Need ideas? See the "20 Product Ideas to Sell" bonus.

PART 03

# Find the real cost in Nivela 3D

Before you quote a price to anyone, X-ray the piece.

1. In **Costs & channels**, set up your printer (power, price and lifespan), the electricity rate from your utility bill and your average failure rate. If you don't know it, start with 10%.
2. In **Materials**, add the filament you use with the price you paid for the spool.
3. In the **Calculator**, enter the weight and time from your slicer, the finishing time and the supplies.
4. Pick the **sales channel** (direct sale, Etsy, Amazon…) so the fees are included.
5. Save it as a **product**. That way you never redo the math for the same piece.

PART 04

# Pricing: margin is not markup

The most expensive beginner mistake is adding a percentage on top of cost and thinking that's the profit.

| | Wrong math | Right math |
|---|---|---|
| Total cost of the piece | $10.00 | $10.00 |
| I want to make | 40% on top of cost | 40% of the selling price |
| Price | $14.00 | $16.67 |
| What you really keep | $4.00 (28.6% of price) | $6.67 (40% of price) |

With the right math, price = **cost ÷ (1 − margin)**. Channel fees come out of that divisor too. The Nivela 3D calculator does it for you. For your first sales, aim for a **margin between 30% and 50%** and adjust over time.

**Minimum price:** write down the lowest price at which the piece still makes a profit. Don't negotiate below it. It's better to lose the sale than to pay to work.

PART 05

# Where to make your first sales

Start where people already know you. Trust sells before any ad.

- **Instagram and Facebook:** a good photo + a short video of the print + "I can add your name". Reply to DMs fast.
- **Friends, family and coworkers:** show your pieces in person or in group chats. Early sales often come from people who already trust you.
- **Referrals:** offer a small gift (a keychain) to anyone who refers a customer who buys.
- **Local shops and markets:** gift shops, florists, pet stores and craft fairs can resell or place orders.

- **Holidays:** Mother's Day, Father's Day, Teacher Appreciation Week, Halloween, Christmas and kids' parties drive personalized orders.
- **Marketplaces (Etsy, Amazon Handmade):** great to scale, but with higher fees. Join once you know your cost and price per channel.

PART 06

## Launch offers without burning your margin

A discount on a thin margin becomes a loss. Add value instead of taking value away.

- **A gift instead of a discount:** "Buy the vase and get a keychain with your name." It costs you little and means a lot to the customer.
- **Bundles:** group 2 or 3 pieces for slightly less than the sum. The order value goes up and the margin holds.
- **Personalization as an upgrade:** the standard piece has one price; with a name or special color, an add-on.
- **Deadlines, not discounts:** "Orders by Friday ship Monday" creates urgency without giving up a cent.

PART 07

## Your first 30 days

| Week | Focus | Goal |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Set up Nivela 3D, pick 3 products, calculate cost and price for each. | 3 products saved with a minimum price. |
| 2 | Print samples, photograph them and post on Instagram, Facebook and to friends. | Samples ready and 5 posts published. |
| 3 | Answer every message the same day, send clear quotes and ask for a deposit. | First 3 to 5 sales. |
| 4 | Log every sale in Nivela 3D, ask for reviews and customer photos, review your prices. | Know your real monthly profit and which piece sells best. |

PART 08

## The costliest beginner mistakes

- Quoting a price "off the top of your head" and finding out later the math didn't work.
- Accepting an order with a deadline you can't meet.
- Printing a custom piece without a deposit and an approved preview.
- Copying a competitor's price without knowing your own cost.
- Not logging sales: at the end of the month you feel like you worked a lot and earned little.

- Selling pieces with protected characters and brands and getting your listing or shop taken down.

PART 09

## Checklist before accepting a sale

☐ I know the real cost of this piece (not just the filament).

☐ The price is above my minimum price, with channel fees included.

☐ I agreed in writing on model, color, size, quantity, price, shipping and lead time.

☐ I received the deposit (or full payment) before starting.

☐ For custom pieces, the customer approved the preview.

☐ The lead time fits my print queue with room for one failure.

☐ I'll log the sale in Nivela 3D as soon as it's paid.